INTRODUCTION

In the frigid mid-winter of 1544, two children were sent north from Kandahar to Kabul, 500 kilometres away. While the snow fell silently and relentlessly on the desolate landscape, the small party stumbled on through the mountain passes and ravines, their horses' steaming breaths loud in the night. There were a number of women in the party including Maham Anaga and Jiji Anaga, and they tried to comfort the children, two-year-old Mirak, and his four-year-old sister, Baca. But their passage was terrifying in the slate-black dark, filled with dangers, the shifting snow, the howling winds, and the djinns they knew skulked beside crossroads and caves. The journey was all the more frightening, for they were hostages, and they feared for their lives. From time to time, they would halt at the stark homes of local Hazara chieftains and the men, their voluminous turbans grown monstrously huge in the flickering candlelight, would gather around the frightened children, who were travelling in disguise because of the threat to their lives. The child Mirak howled in terror at the endless night till a lamp was brought to him, providing meagre comfort. The 'lights of joy', we are assured, 'showed themselves in his cheeks'. Eventually, the two hostages arrived in Kabul, where they had been summoned by their uncle Kamran. For these were no ordinary children, but the daughter and son of Humayun, once Padshah of Hindustan—Bakshi Banu Begum, and Abu'l-Fath Jalal-ud-din Muhammad Akbar, known simply as Akbar.

Though Abu'l Fazl[*] with retrospective confidence would claim that Kamran grew contrite and abashed when he beheld the 'lustrous forehead' of the child Akbar, the truth was a great deal more prosaic. Humayun had lost the empire he had inherited in Hindustan[†] from his father, Babur, and had had to abandon Akbar almost as soon as the child was born, besieged by his own brothers as well as local chieftains, and one especially inexorable foe, Sher Shah Sur. For Humayun was not the only claimant to the fledgling Mughal Empire that Babur had founded. His brothers, Kamran, Askari, and Hindal, all considered themselves equally worthy contenders and challenged him for the throne as soon as Babur died. Kamran, especially, was ambitious, driven, and ruthless, and when he